

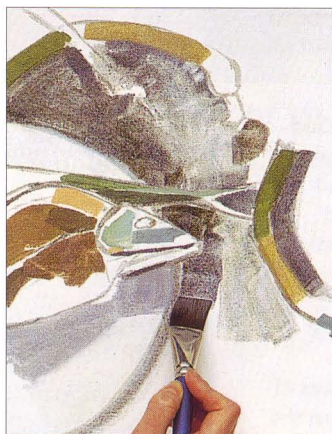
LOW-KEY & HIGH-KEY COLOR

LOW-KEY PAINTINGS are usually defined by their subdued tones and color mixtures that tend toward neutral browns and grays. High-key paintings are exactly the opposite, with simple mixtures of pure, bright, saturated colors, often mixed with white. The strong distinction between high- and low-key painting

needs to be made to enable us to focus our use of color in terms of our approach to subject matter. Many paintings contain elements of each, but certain subjects lend themselves well to the use of high-key or low-key color. These simple exercises show how easily the mood of a subject can change.

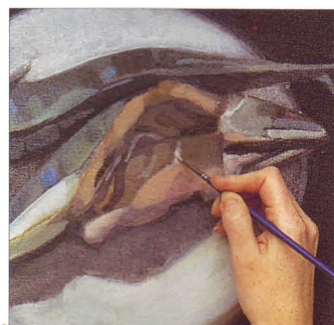


LOW-KEY PAINTINGS are often created with tertiary colors (a mixture of three or more colors), such as the Payne's Gray above. These can produce neutral, unsaturated hues. Some artists use a small range of neutral colors that are similar in mood and tone, but their paintings can vary enormously in atmosphere. This means that a work may be low in key and somber in mood, but it can either be a quiet, reflective study suffused with a subtle atmosphere, or painted in a dramatic way on a dark ground. Some subjects are by their nature low-key, such as moonlit scenes or dimly lit interiors, but almost any subject can be treated in a low-key manner.



1 ▲ Block in main areas of the composition using a large brush and mixes of opaque green, blue, and Payne's Gray, thinned with turpentine. Paint with loose brushstrokes to keep the composition simple.

2 ▶ Paint over the first layers of color with thicker opaque paint that has been mixed with a little oil painting medium. Use a medium-sized flat brush to capture the shape of the fish most effectively.



3 ◀ When the tone and depth of the composition is complete, add finer details and opaque highlights with a small round brush. Keep the highlights soft and subtle and without harsh lines.

Gutted Mackerel

This painting is composed of subdued, almost neutral colors that create a soft light and a gentle atmosphere.

A limited palette of colors keeps the work more powerful and controlled.

Opaque highlights help to create a subtle movement through the painting.



Elaine Halden

